NONPARAMETRIC ESTIMATION FROM INCOMPLETE OBSERVATIONS*

E. L. Kaplan
University of California Radiation Laboratory
AND
Paul Meier
University of Chicago

In lifetesting, medical follow-up, and other fields the observation of the time of occurrence of the event of interest (called a *death*) may be prevented for some of the items of the sample by the previous occurrence of some other event (called a *loss*). Losses may be either accidental or controlled, the latter resulting from a decision to terminate certain observations. In either case it is usually assumed in this paper that the lifetime (age at death) is independent of the potential loss time; in